

IL CHUBBY BABI

Bruno Belotti

Last edited on July 27, 2026

CONTENTS

I STARTERS

Much empty! 3

II MAINS & COMPONENTS

Burger Buns 5

Burger Sauce 6

Café de Paris 7

Garlic Shrimp Stir Fry 8

Mac & Cheese 9

Moussaka 10

Piadine (Italian flatbread) . . 12

Neapolitan Pizza 13

Chicken in a Basket 14

Risotto Patrio 15

French Onion Soup 16

Stroganoff Pasta 17

Sushi rice (鮭飯 / すしめし) . . . 18

III SWEETS

Engadine Walnut Tart 20

The Perfect Cheesecake 21

Cooked Wine Tart 25

IL CHUBBY BABI

BRUNO'S RECIPE BOOK

I STARTERS

IL CHUBBY BABI

BRUNO'S RECIPE BOOK

MUCH EMPTY!

Very nothing!

II MAINS & COMPONENTS

BURGER BUNS

Makes anywhere between 4 very large buns and 8 small ones.

Ingredients

Bread

- 450 g AP flour
- 235 ml water
- 1 egg
- 3 tbsp melted butter
- 3 tbsp granulated sugar
- 7 g dry yeast
- Salt
- Sesame seeds

Egg wash

- 1 egg
- 1 tbsp milk

Put the **yeast** in the **water** and let it wake up,¹ then add the **egg**, **butter**, **sugar**, and **salt**. Mix well while adding the **flour**. Let rise for 2h in a warm place.² Form the desired number of balls (4 to 8), set on an oven tray, cover, and let rise for another hour. Preheat the oven to 190°C, brush the buns with the well-mixed **egg** and **milk**, then bake for 15-20 minutes.

¹Add a pinch of flour and sugar to help. Wait a few minutes, until the surface foams.

²I usually leave it in the oven with the light on.

BURGER SAUCE

Ingredients

- 125 g mayonnaise
- 60 g ketchup
- 15 g shallot or onion
- 25 g of sriracha or chili
- 15 g Dijon mustard
- 60 g (=1 medium) pickle
- ½ garlic clove
- 2 g salt (a generous pinch)
- 2 g pepper

Blend **all the ingredients** with a (hand-held) food processor and serve. Can be done without a food processor by finely mincing all the solid ingredients with a knife.

CAFÉ DE PARIS

A rich Swiss steak herbs sauce

Ingredients

- 125 g butter
- 1 egg yolk
- 1 generous tsp Dijon mustard
- ½ tbsp Cognac (or Brandy)
- ½ tsp white wine
- ½ tsp rosemary
- ½ tsp parsley
- 1 small anchovy
- ½ tsp thyme
- ½ tsp ground shallot
- ½ tsp ground garlic
- ½ tsp mild curry powder
- Pinch of salt
- Pinch of pepper
- Pinch of paprika

Place the softened **butter** and **all the other ingredients** in a bowl. Mash thoroughly and mix with a fork until a paste forms. Using plastic wrap, shape into a log and let it firm up in the refrigerator. Melt a tbsp or two on your steak.

GARLIC SHRIMP STIR FRY

For 2-3 servings.

Ingredients

- Rice or other side of choice
- 6 garlic cloves, minced
- 60 ml ($\frac{1}{4}$ cup) soy sauce
- 60 ml ($\frac{1}{4}$ cup) water
- 2 tbsp light brown sugar
- 1 tbsp sesame oil
- 1 tbsp vegetable oil
- 1 tbsp chili sauce (like *sambal oelek*)
- 1 tbsp corn starch
- 1 red bell pepper, sliced
- Any other veggies of choice
- Shrimp or any other protein of choice¹

Start by cooking the **rice** (or side of choice). In a small bowl, combine the minced **garlic** with the **water**, **soy sauce**, **sugar**, **sesame oil**, **chili sauce**, and **corn starch**. Whisk until smooth.

In a large skillet, add the **vegetable oil** over medium-high heat, add the **bell pepper** and the other **veggies**, depending on their cooking time. Sauté until softened (~ 5 minutes), then add the **shrimp** and cook until pink and opaque.

Pour the **sauce** into the skillet and cook until it thickens enough to coat the shrimp. Serve over the rice.

¹If making this dish with beef, chicken, or pork, consider *velveting* the meat first: this simple and fast tenderizing step will give the meat that restaurant-like texture: for every 250 g (8 oz) of striped meat, add $\frac{3}{4}$ tsp of baking soda, mix well, refrigerate for ~ 20 minutes, rinse, and shake off the excess water before stir frying.

MAC & CHEESE

Daniel's favorite. Serves 4 (or 1.5 Daniels)

Ingredients

- 460 g elbow macaroni
- 60 g butter
- 36 g AP flour
- 480 ml milk
- Grated cheese:
 - 70 g blue cheese
 - 70g parmesan
 - 80 g sharp cheddar
 - 60 g gouda
- 3 cloves of garlic, crushed or finely minced
- Salt and pepper

Start cooking the **macaroni** to *al dente*. In the meantime, melt the **butter** in a large stainless steel pan, add the **flour** and vigorously whisk until smooth.¹ While whisking, slowly add the **milk** to the mixture. Progressively add all the **grated cheese** and the **garlic**.

Season to taste with **salt and pepper**, then serve on the warm macaroni.

¹The result is what the French call “*roux*”

MOUSSAKA

Ingredients

For the Meat Sauce

- 1 kg (2.2 lb) lean ground meat ($\frac{1}{2}$ beef and $\frac{1}{2}$ pork)
- 100 g (7 tbsp) unseasoned tomato sauce (*passata*)
- 25 g (1.5 tbsp) tomato paste
- 1 onion
- 1 celery stalk
- 2 garlic cloves
- $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp sugar
- 1 glass (175 ml / $\frac{3}{4}$ cup) red wine
- 2 bay leaves
- 1 cinnamon stick
- Star anise, to taste
- Parsley, to taste
- Nutmeg, to taste
- Olive oil, as needed
- Salt and black pepper, to taste

For the Layers

- 1 kg (2.2 lb) eggplants
- If frying:
 - Flour, as needed
 - Frying oil
- 3 potatoes (optional)

For the Yogurt Béchamel

- 500 g (2 cups) milk
- 250 g (1 cup) Greek yogurt
- 50 g ($\frac{1}{3}$ cup) flour
- 50 g (3.5 tbsp) butter
- Nutmeg, to taste
- Black pepper, to taste

To Assemble

- Parmesan cheese, to taste
- Breadcrumbs, to taste
- Dried oregano, to taste
- Olive oil, as needed

Start with the meat sauce:

Roughly chop the **celery** and **onion**. Sauté them with the **garlic** until softened, then add the **sugar**. Add the **ground meat** and brown it over high heat, breaking it up with a wooden spoon. After about 5 minutes, deglaze with the **red wine** and season with the **bay leaves**, **star anise**, and **cinnamon**. Stir in the **tomato passata** and **tomato paste**, mix well, and let simmer over medium-high heat, then add the chopped **parsley**. Season with **nutmeg**, **salt**, and **black pepper**. Reduce the heat and cook uncovered for approximately 1.5 hours.

Prepare the eggplants and potatoes:

Slice the **eggplants** lengthwise into slices about 1 cm ($\frac{3}{8}$ in) thick, and the **potatoes** into slices about $\frac{1}{2}$ cm ($\frac{1}{4}$ in) thick. Traditionally, the vegetables are dredged in flour and fried, but alternatively they may be brushed with olive oil and baked for a simpler, lighter version.¹ Set them aside.

Prepare the yogurt béchamel:

Heat the **milk** separately. In a saucepan, melt the **butter** over medium-low heat and stir in the **flour** to make a golden roux.² Gradually add the hot milk while whisking constantly to eliminate any lumps, then season with **salt**, **black pepper**, and **nutmeg**. Once you have a thick béchamel, remove it from the heat and let it cool for 5 minutes before stirring in the **Greek yogurt**, then adjust the seasoning with salt, pepper, and nutmeg.

Assemble the moussaka:

Grease a deep baking dish (base approximately 26×20 cm (10×8 in)) with **olive oil**, spread a thin layer of béchamel over the bottom, arrange all the potatoes in a single layer, add a layer of eggplants, and sprinkle with **Parmesan cheese**, **breadcrumbs**, and **dried oregano**. Cover with all of the meat sauce. Arrange another layer of eggplants, then sprinkle again with Parmesan cheese, breadcrumbs, and dried oregano. Cover everything with the remaining béchamel, then finish with another sprinkling of breadcrumbs and Parmesan cheese. Bake in a preheated oven at 180°C (350°F) for approximately 45 minutes.

¹In this case, sprinkle the slices with salt on both sides and let them release some of their moisture for about $\frac{1}{2}$ hour, then pat them thoroughly dry before assembling the moussaka.

²A *roux* is the classic French mixture of equal parts butter and flour cooked together and used as the base for many sauces.

PIADINE (Italian flatbread)

Makes 3 piadine

- 1 dl water
- 180 g flour
- 1 tbsp milk
- 1 tbsp olive oil
- $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp salt

In a bowl, mix together **all the ingredients**, adding the **flour** gradually.

Let the dough rest for 10 minutes (covered or wrapped in plastic in the refrigerator).

Divide the dough into 3 balls and roll them out. Cook in a skillet over medium-high heat for about 1 minute, until bubbles form.

NEAPOLITAN PIZZA

From Brian Lagerstrom's recipe. Makes 4 pizzas. Dough needs to rise overnight!

- 450 g water
- 6 pinches active dry yeast ($\frac{1}{8}$ tsp)
- 665 g '00' flour (or all purpose flour)
- 20 g salt

Add the **yeast** to the **water**,¹ then add the **flour** and **salt**. Mix well with a spoon, then knead with a stand mixer² until smooth and elastic. Cover and let rest for 30 minutes.

Perform a strength-building fold to develop the gluten,³ then cover and let rest for another 30 minutes.

Perform another strength-building fold, then cover and let the dough proof at room temperature for 12 hours.

Divide the dough into 4 balls and place them in lightly oiled containers in the refrigerator for at least 2 hours, or up to 5 days.

Remove from the refrigerator 3 hours before making the pizza. Stretch the pizzas on a well-floured surface, add the desired toppings,^{4,5} then bake in a preheated oven, ideally on a pizza stone, for about 10 minutes (the bottom should begin to develop nicely dark or slightly charred spots).

*"In Naples they invented pizza.
And everyone honks their horns,
because they want to have pizza."
—the Rizzello Brothers.*

¹To properly activate the yeast, dissolve it in warm water with a teaspoon of sugar or flour and let it sit for 5–10 minutes, until foamy.

²If you do not have a stand mixer, the dough can also be kneaded by hand. However, as with bread, the resulting crust will generally be less open, airy, and professional-looking.

³*Strength-building fold*: without removing the dough from its container, grab one side of the dough, stretch it upward, and fold it over to the opposite side. Repeat on all four sides, forming an "X". Turn the dough over so the seam is facing down before letting it rest again. Brian Lagerstrom has several videos, including the one linked under the title of this recipe, demonstrating this technique.

⁴I recommend stretching the pizza (strictly by hand), then transferring it to a well-floured wooden or aluminum pizza peel before adding the toppings. Trying to lift a fully topped pizza directly from the work surface requires considerable skill and, in inexperienced hands, often ends in disaster. Also, try to leave the pizza on the peel for as little time as possible, especially after adding wet ingredients (such as tomato sauce), since the moisture will cause it to stick to the peel.

⁵Should the reader, or one of the prospective dinner guests, intend to top the pizza with *pineapple*, I would like to point out that this is an utterly barbaric act, deserving of public humiliation.

CHICKEN IN A BASKET

The Attinghausen-style recipe. A.k.a. “Devil’s Chicken” (—Bailee Z., lactose intolerant.) Serves 2.

Ingredients

For the marinade

- 1 whole chicken (1 kg)
- 2 dl sour cream
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp black pepper
- 2 tsp salt
- a pinch of dried garlic

- White wine, for deglazing
- 1 dl vegetable stock
- 2.5 dl heavy cream
- 1.5 tsp mustard
- 0.5 tsp Madras curry powder
- 0.5 tsp tarragon
- 60 g butter
- black pepper, to taste
- salt, to taste

For the sauce

- 1 large or 2 small shallots
- 2 tbsp olive oil

To serve

- French fries
- Cornichons

Marinate the **chicken** in the well-mixed marinade for at least 4 hours in the refrigerator, turning it occasionally. Remove it from the refrigerator 30 minutes before roasting. Roast the chicken in the center of the oven¹ at 200°C for about 1 hour. Cook for 20 minutes on each side, then switch to the grill setting for another 10 minutes per side. If serving **French fries**, bake them during the last 20 minutes of the chicken’s cooking time, then continue baking them for another 10 minutes while the chicken rests outside the oven.

For the sauce, sauté the **shallot** in the **olive oil** and deglaze with the **white wine**. Once the wine has evaporated, add the **vegetable stock** and cook for 1 minute. Add the **cream**, **curry powder**, **black pepper**, **tarragon**, and **mustard**. Simmer gently for 10–15 minutes until slightly reduced (the butter will loosen it again), then stir in the **butter** and finally adjust the **salt** to taste. If necessary, keep the sauce over very low heat, stirring occasionally, until the chicken is ready. It should have a nice glossy appearance. Serve half a chicken per person in a basket with the sauce, half a cornichon, and the French fries on the side. Eat strictly with your hands.

¹Alternatively, directly on the oven rack. In this case, place a baking tray filled with water underneath the chicken to catch the dripping fat.

RISOTTO PATRIO

Perfected, in my not-so-humble opinion, from Carlo Emilio Gadda's version. Serves 4.

Ingredients

- 1 onion, finely diced
- 350 g risotto rice¹
- High-quality Lodi butter, *quantum prodest*
- 1.5 L richly flavored beef stock
- 0.2 g (or 50 threads) saffron
- White wine, for deglazing
- Grated Parmigiano Reggiano
- Porcini, chanterelles, or morel mushrooms

Equipment

- Tinned copper saucepan (or aluminum, but do not use a non-stick pot)
- Ladle
- Wooden spoon

In a separate bowl or pot, prepare 1.5 L of **saffron-infused beef stock** so that it is ready to use. If available, add the **mushrooms** to the stock as well. In the saucepan, melt some **butter**² and gently cook the finely diced **onion**. As soon as the buttery onion mixture begins to sizzle, add the **rice** and toast it, stirring against the copper bottom. Deglaze with the **white wine**. Then begin cooking the rice by adding the stock a ladleful at a time until the rice is cooked: not overdone, but just beyond *al dente*. Remove the risotto from the heat, *mantecate*³ it, and add as much **Parmigiano Reggiano** as you like. Cover with a lid and let it rest for 10 minutes before serving.⁴

¹The Vialone type is ideal, but the Arborio is easier to find in the US.

²Optionally, add a tablespoon of olive oil so that the butter is less likely to burn.

³To *mantecare* a risotto means to vigorously stir in cold butter and grated Parmigiano Reggiano off the heat until the risotto becomes smooth, creamy, and glossy.

⁴Best enjoyed with some rustic bread and a glass of red wine.

FRENCH ONION SOUP

Serves 4

Ingredients

Soup

- 6 yellow onions¹
- 55 g butter
- 125 ml red wine
- 30 ml Cognac (Brandy will work, too)
- ½ L chicken stock
- ½ L beef stock
- 1 tbsp flour
- 1 pinch ground nutmeg

Topping

- 200 g grated Gruyère
- Toasted baguette slices
- 1 garlic clove

Cut the **onions** into quarters, then thinly slice them into short strips. In a large saucepan over medium heat, soften the onions in the **butter** for 15 minutes. Continue cooking over high heat for another 15 minutes, or until the onions are well caramelized, stirring constantly and scraping the bottom of the pan. Deglaze with the **red wine** and the **Cognac** (or Brandy), then reduce until almost dry. Add the **chicken stock**, **beef stock**, **flour**, and **nutmeg**. Simmer over medium-high heat for 30 minutes, or until the soup has reduced by about half. Season with salt and pepper.

Ladle the soup into bowls, top each with the garlic-rubbed toasted baguette slices, generously cover with the grated Gruyère, and shortly broil in the oven until the cheese is melted, bubbling, and golden.

¹The European variety, which rarely exceeds 3 inches in ø, versus the softball+ size of PNW onions. Plan accordingly.

STROGANOFF PASTA

*Serves 4.***Ingredients**

- 1 kg sirloin or chuck steak
- 50 g (3 tbsp) soy sauce
- 35 g (2 tbsp) Worcestershire sauce (15 g for the marinade and 20 g for the sauce)
- 200 g or about 1 onion, finely diced
- 450 g button mushrooms, sliced
- 4–5 garlic cloves (minced or crushed)
- High-smoke-point vegetable oil
- Salt and black pepper
- 175 g (1 glass) dry white wine
- 25 g (1.5 tbsp) tomato paste
- 15 g (2 tbsp) flour
- 400 g beef stock, with 3 packets unflavoured powdered gelatin dissolved in it (optional)
- 25 g (1⅔ tbsp) Dijon mustard
- 450 g pasta of your choice
- 65 g butter
- 75 g heavy cream

Tenderize (or *Jaccard*) the **steak** by piercing it with a fork. Place it in a bag with the **soy sauce** and 15 g of the **Worcestershire sauce**, then refrigerate for 15–20 minutes while preparing the remaining ingredients.

Pat the steak dry and heat some **oil** in a heavy-bottomed skillet (ideally cast iron). Add the steak, pressing firmly against the pan. Cook over medium-high heat for 1.5 minutes on one side, or until well browned, then 2–3 minutes on the other side. Transfer the meat to a plate and loosely wrap it in foil.

Add another splash of oil to the skillet, then add the **mushrooms** with a pinch of salt. Stir and deglaze¹ the pan with a wooden spoon. Sauté for 4–5 minutes, until some of the mushrooms' moisture has evaporated. Add the **onion** with another pinch of salt, stir, and cook for 3–4 minutes. Add the **garlic** and cook for about 20 seconds, then pour in the **white wine**. Deglaze thoroughly and, once the wine has reduced slightly, stir in the **tomato paste** and **flour**. These will coat the bottom of the pan in about a minute.

Add the **beef stock** with the dissolved **gelatin**, deglaze, and bring to a boil. Stir in the **Dijon mustard**, the remaining **Worcestershire sauce**, and some **black pepper**. Cover and let the sauce simmer gently for about 10 minutes, then stir in the **heavy cream**. Meanwhile, cook the **pasta**. Slice the steak into thin strips and add it to the reduced sauce. Toss everything together, ensuring the meat is heated through, and serve.

¹In this recipe, as in many others—particularly in French cuisine—deglazing is an essential step that builds a deep and complex flavor.

SUSHI RICE (鮭飯 / すしめし)

Makes enough for ~8 rolls

- 360 g (2 cups) raw sushi rice (e.g., pearl)
- 60 g ($\frac{1}{4}$ cup) rice vinegar
- 4 tsp sugar
- 1 tsp salt

Start cooking the **rice** at least 4 hours before you plan to start rolling your sushi.¹ While the rice cooks, mix **all other ingredients** together in a glass or bowl.² Once the rice is done, mix in the liquid, stir well, and let the rice cool completely, covered.

¹Ensure you prepare the sushi with style, like in a real おまかせ.

²Microwaving the mix for 10 seconds will help dissolve the salt and sugar.

IL CHUBBY BABI

BRUNO'S RECIPE BOOK

III SWEETS

ENGADINE WALNUT TART

Ingredients

Dough

- 325 g flour
- 100 g sugar
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 1 pinch salt
- 1 egg
- 2 tbsp cold water
- 175 g butter

Filling

- 200 g sugar
- 0.5 dl hot water
- 2.5 dl heavy cream
- 300 g walnuts
- 50 g honey

Mix the **flour** and **butter** using a mixer. Then combine the flour-butter mixture with the **sugar**, **baking powder**, and **salt** in a bowl. Add the **egg** and the **water**, and mix with a fork. Wrap in plastic wrap and refrigerate for about 30 minutes.

For the filling, caramelize the **sugar** slowly, pour in the **water**, and bring to a boil. Add the **cream** and simmer until the caramel has dissolved. Stir in the **walnuts** and **honey**. Continue stirring for a few minutes until the mixture thickens. Then let it cool.

Preheat the oven to 200°C conventional heat (top and bottom). Divide the dough into three parts. Roll out one third into a disc about 24 cm in $\varnothing$ and refrigerate. Roll out the remaining dough on a lightly floured surface into a disc about 32 cm in $\varnothing$ and place it in the buttered pan. Spread the filling evenly over the dough. Fold the edges of the dough inward and cover the tart with the smaller dough disc. Press the edges firmly with a fork and prick the top. Bake on the middle rack for about 30 minutes. Allow to cool completely (this is quite important).

The *Engadiner* (or *Bündner*) *Nusstorte* ('nut pie') is traditional of the alpine region of *Engiadina*, in the Kanton of Graubünden, Switzerland. This is my favorite pie ever.

THE PERFECT CHEESECAKE

A recipe by Jerry P. Fairley, reproduced almost verbatim from his own cookbook.

Ingredients

Crust

- 2 cups (200 g) graham cracker crumbs
- 2 tbsp (25 g) granulated sugar
- Pinch of salt
- 5 tbsp (70 g) unsalted butter

Filling

- 2 lbs (900 g) cream cheese **at room T°**
- 1 $\frac{1}{3}$ cups (265 g) granulated sugar
- Pinch of salt
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 4 large eggs¹
- $\frac{2}{3}$ cup (160 g) sour cream
- $\frac{2}{3}$ cup (160 g) heavy whipping cream

Toppings (optional)

- 2 cups (460 g) sour cream
- $\frac{1}{3}$ cup (40 g) powdered sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 12 oz (340 g) fresh raspberries, blackberries, or strawberries, finely diced
- $\frac{1}{2}$ cup (100 g) granulated sugar
- $\frac{1}{2}$ cup (120 g) water

Special equipment

- a 9-in (23 cm) diameter, 2 $\frac{3}{4}$ inch (7 cm) high springform pan
- Heavy-duty **18-in (45 cm) wide** aluminum foil (do not try to use regular-width aluminum foil)
- Parchment paper
- A large, high-sided roasting pan (large enough to contain the springform pan)

Crust:

Unroll a sheet of **parchment paper** the size of the **springform pan**. Using the bottom of the springform pan as a pattern, draw a circle on the parchment paper and carefully cut it out. It should just fit in the bottom of the pan. Set the parchment circle aside for now.

Spread out a kitchen towel on the counter and set the springform pan, upside-down, on the towel.² Carefully and gently tear-off a square of the wide **aluminum foil** that will completely cover the entire bottom and sides of the springform pan. Place the foil over the bottom of the pan and gently fold the

¹US standard, ~57 g each

²To avoid tearing or puncturing the delicate aluminum foil

foil down over the sides, then turn the pan over and crimp the foil all around the lip. Do all of this very carefully, on top of the towel, so you don't get even a little pinhole in the foil—if you do, start over with a new piece of aluminum foil. Once you get the first layer of aluminum foil on the springform pan, turn the pan upside-down again and put another piece of aluminum foil over the bottom and sides of the pan in exactly the same way as the first piece. This second layer of foil is an insurance policy in case the first layer has a tiny pinhole that you missed.

Put the **butter** in a microwave-proof bowl and heat it for 30 seconds. Wait for a couple of minutes, then swirl the bowl around and heat it again for 30 s. Let the bowl sit until any solid butter that is left melts completely. Place a baking rack in the bottom third of the oven and preheat to 350°F (177°C). Roughly break-up the **graham crackers** and pulse them in a food processor until they are finely-ground. Put the crumbs in a small or medium mixing bowl. Stir in the **sugar** and pinch of **salt**, then pour in the melted butter and mix well with your hands.

Keeping the pan on the kitchen towel (to minimize the chance of pinholes in the foil), put the circle of parchment paper into the bottom, inside the foil-wrapped springform pan, and dump in all the graham cracker crust mixture. Press the crumbs into the bottom of the pan,³ leaving just a slightly thicker crust along the outside edge of the pan. Be very careful not to tear the aluminum foil while you do this (or while doing anything else).⁴ Carefully (so you don't make a hole in the aluminum foil) place the springform pan on the rack in the oven and bake for 10 minutes. Remove the pan and place it on the kitchen towel. Reduce the oven temperature to 325°F (325°C).

Filling:

You can do all the following steps with a handheld electric mixer; however, if you have one, it is (a lot) easier to use a stand-mixer, and the finished product is actually better. Although it's hard work to mix the ingredients enough with a hand-mixer, with persisence, you can do it. The moral of the story is: if you want a good cheesecake, don't short the mixing times below, just because you are using a hand-mixer!

Put 2 quarts of water on to boil while you are preparing the filling, and keep them hot. You will need them after you make the filling, when you bake the cheesecake.

Cut the **cream cheese** up into chunks and place it all in a large mixing

³I usually use the bottom of a measuring cup first, then my fingers (or a spoon) to finish the job.

⁴If it seems as though I'm making a really big deal out of getting a hole in the aluminium foil, that's because I am. Even the tiniest hole will let water in the pan and spoil the crust. Making a good filling is tedious, but easy. The hardest part of making a good cheesecake is keeping the crust from being soggy. Trust me on this—it took me years to work out the crust part.

bowl. Mix the cream cheese⁵ on medium speed for at least 4 minutes, or until it is light and fluffy. Add the **sugar**, then beat the mixture for another 4 minutes. Add the **salt** and beat for 2 minutes, then add the **vanilla** and beat for another 2 minutes. Add the **eggs**, one at a time, beating the batter for 1 minute after adding each egg. Add the **sour cream**, beating for 4 minutes, then add the **heavy cream**, beating for another 4 minutes. After each addition (sugar, salt, vanilla, eggs, sour cream, heavy cream), use a spatula to scrape the bottom and sides of the mixing bowl, to make sure all the little chunks of cream cheese get whipped and all the ingredients are completely incorporated.

Baking the cheesecake:

Carefully set the foil-wrapped springform pan in the large, high-sided roasting pan. Pour the cream cheese filling into the springform pan, on top of the graham cracker crust, and gently smooth the top with a rubber spatula if needed. Place the roasting pan (with the springform pan inside) on the lower rack (i.e., in the bottom third) of the oven. Pour the hot water (heated up in the previous step) into the roasting pan until it comes about halfway up the sides of the springform pan. The water should be 1¼ to 1½ inches (3 to 4 cm) deep.

Bake the cheesecake in the oven at 325°F (165°C) for at least 1½ hours. After 1½ hours, check to see if the cake is done by putting a bamboo skewer or a knife into the middle of the cake; if it comes out clean, the cake is done, but if there is goop (filling) on the knife, it needs more time. The top should be lightly browned; if it starts to look too brown, but the cheesecake still isn't completely done, use a piece of aluminum foil to loosely cover the top. The exact baking time is probably highly dependent on the oven. The original recipe says 1½ hours, but I have found it takes closer to 2½ hours in our oven, and I sometimes resort to turning up the temperature to 350°F (175°C). Make sure to top-up the water in the roasting pan if it gets too low, but I rarely find I need to add more water.

Once the cheesecake is set, turn off the oven and open the door about an inch, leaving the cheesecake inside. Let the cake cool for at least another hour, or longer if you like. I usually leave it until it is almost completely at room temperature. This helps keep the top of the cheesecake from developing cracks.

Once the cheesecake is cooled, take it out of the oven and cover it with foil, without letting the foil touch the top of the cheesecake. Put it in the refrigerator and chill overnight, or for a minimum of 4 hours.

Preparing the toppings:

While the cheesecake is baking, place the **sour cream** in a medium sized bowl and stir in the powdered sugar and vanilla. Mix until smooth, then cover and chill until you are ready to serve the cake.

⁵If you have a stand-mixer, use the paddle attachment.

Put the **raspberries** (or **blackberries**, or **strawberries**, or whatever you are using), **sugar**, and **water** into a small saucepan. Simmer the mixture, occasionally using a potato masher to crush-up the fruit. After about 5–10 minutes the syrup will begin to get a little thicker. Once it starts to thicken, remove it from the heat and let it cool. Be careful not to overdo it, because the sauce will thicken more as it cools.

Serving the Cheesecake:

Take the cheesecake out of the refrigerator and remove the aluminum foil. Getting the springform pan off the cake without messing it up can be a little tricky. Try running a blunt knife around the inside of the pan, between the pan and the cake, before opening the latch on the pan. You can also try warming the sides of the pan (the original recipe suggests using a hair-dryer, but I've never had much success with that—I just use a knife). It might help to let the pan sit outside the refrigerator for 10–15 minutes before trying to unmold it, so the sides of the pan can warm up a little.

Anyway, once you unmold the springform pan from the cake, spread the top of the cheesecake with about half the sour cream topping. I suggest using a hot knife to cut the cake. I keep a kitchen towel (or paper towels) and a tall drinking glass full of hot water next to the cake; in between cutting each slice, I stick the knife in the water for a minute, then dry it off with the towel. This makes a mess of the towel, but you can always wash that later. Drizzle a little of the raspberry syrup on each slice and serve.

Note that the recipe for the sour cream topping makes more than you really need. I serve it on the side for people who want extra, but you can also serve the cheesecake without any sour cream dressing (or raspberry sauce, for that matter). The toppings are optional, and you can decide if you want to make (and use) them or not, depending on your tastes.

Making a cheesecake is a lot of work, although it does get easier after you've done it a few times. As I mentioned above, using a stand-mixer is a big help. Most of all, however, I have found the best cheesecakes are made with love! Love of baking, certainly, and also love for the person for whom you are making it. I don't know if you've ever noticed this, but I never make a cheesecake for myself—it's always easier to make it for someone that is dear to you.

COOKED WINE TART

Made with Swiss “Vin Cuit” (literally “cooked wine”). A.k.a. “Tarte au Raisinée.”

Ingredients

- 250 g sweet pastry (see recipe on page 20)
- 3 eggs
- 1 egg yolk
- 1.4 dl double cream¹
- 1 dl Vaud-style *cooked wine*

Prepare the **sweet pastry** and leave it to rest. Roll out the pastry to a thickness of ½ cm and line a buttered and floured 20 cm diameter tart tin. Blind bake the pastry,² for approximately 25 minutes, in an oven at 250°C. Allow to cool without removing it from the tin.

Prepare the custard filling by whisking together the **remaining ingredients**.³ Fill the pastry shell, place it in the preheated oven at 180°C, and finish filling it to the brim once the tart is in the oven, using a spoon.

Leave the oven door slightly ajar until the custard has set, approximately half an hour, and check the degree of doneness by gently shaking the tin. Remove from the tin while still lukewarm and place on a wire rack.

¹A rich Swiss cream with about 45% fat.

²To prevent the pastry base from puffing up during blind baking, cover it with a disc of aluminium foil or baking paper and fill with chickpeas to keep it in place.

³Depending on the degree of reduction of the cooked wine, the quantity may need to be increased up to 1.2 dl.